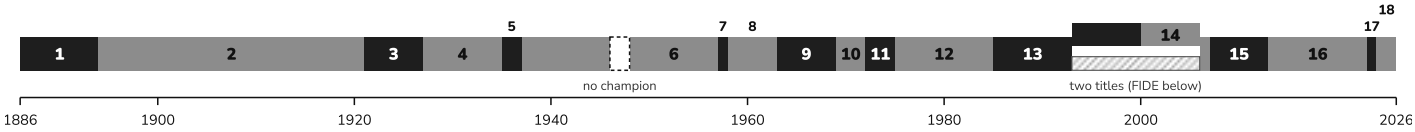
The 18 world chess champions, 1886 to today

Every undisputed world chess champion: the years each held the title, and what each is known for.



#	CHAMPION	COUNTRY	YEARS AS CHAMPION	KNOWN FOR
1	**Wilhelm Steinitz**	United States	**1886–1894**	Showed that patient, positional play beats all-out attack
2	**Emanuel Lasker**	Germany	**1894–1921**	27 years, the longest reign; also a research mathematician
3	**José Raúl Capablanca**	Cuba	**1921–1927**	Endgames; unbeaten from 1916 to 1924
4	**Alexander Alekhine**	France	**1927–1935, 1937–1946**	Fierce, inventive attacks; the only champion to die holding the title
5	**Max Euwe**	Netherlands	**1935–1937**	A maths teacher; later led FIDE (1970–1978)
6	**Mikhail Botvinnik**	Soviet Union	**1948–1957, 1958–1960, 1961–1963**	Three reigns; taught Karpov, Kasparov and Kramnik
7	**Vasily Smyslov**	Soviet Union	**1957–1958**	17 Olympiad medals, a record; a baritone singer
8	**Mikhail Tal**	Soviet Union	**1960–1961**	“The Magician from Riga”; attacking, improvised play
9	**Tigran Petrosian**	Soviet Union	**1963–1969**	“Iron Tigran”: defence that was almost impossible to break
10	**Boris Spassky**	Soviet Union	**1969–1972**	Lost the 1972 Reykjavík match, which drew more interest than any before or since
11	**Bobby Fischer**	United States	**1972–1975**	U.S. champion 8 times; invented the time increment
12	**Anatoly Karpov**	Soviet Union	**1975–1985**	160+ tournament wins
13	**Garry Kasparov**	Soviet Union, then Russia	**1985–2000**	World no. 1 for 255 months, a record
14	**Vladimir Kramnik**	Russia	**2000–2007**	Reunited the title in 2006
15	**Viswanathan Anand**	India	**2007–2013**	India’s first grandmaster; famous for how fast he played
16	**Magnus Carlsen**	Norway	**2013–2023**	Peak rating 2882, the highest on record
17	**Ding Liren**	China	**2023–2024**	China’s first champion; 100 games unbeaten
18	**Gukesh Dommaraju**	India	**2024–**	The youngest undisputed champion, at 18

Why some lists have 22: from 1993 to 2006 there were two titles. FIDE also crowned Alexander Khalifman, Ruslan Ponomariov, Rustam Kasimdzhanov and Veselin Topalov. This card counts the 18 undisputed champions.

Facts from Wikipedia’s ‘World Chess Championship’ article and each champion’s article, read 7 November 2026. Years are each champion’s reign in the undisputed line; Kasparov’s 1993–2000 and Kramnik’s 2000–2006 are the Classical title.

From the RankUp Chess video ‘All 18 World Chess Champions, Explained Simply’. RankUp Chess is an offline chess app, with bots that start at a child’s very first game. stillwareltd.com/rankupchess